



Properly positioning the mousepad and stand

place—depending on placement, of course.

We found that just these simple steps helped us optimise our mouse for gaming, and headshots in Counter Strike were a lot simpler—the mouse moved freely and smaller hand movements were necessary.



Overclock 'em!

Yes, you *can* overclock mice. Depending on the mouse, it'll either drastically improve performance, not have any effect, or just damage it beyond repair (if you push too far). First up, we should tell you that doing this voids all warranties, so don't start shooting off angry e-mails to us if you mess it up. Next, you should know whether your mouse can handle overclocking. Those of you with Razer mice need not attempt this, because the drivers already support changing refresh rates—the same applies to other mice that allow you to change refresh rates. Also, high-quality mice such as the MX518 perform exceptionally well at the native 125 Hz.

Now most mice have refresh rates of 125 Hz, and you can increase this to a whopping 1000 Hz. Basically, the idea is, the faster the refresh rate, the lower the response time. At 125 Hz, this is about 8 ms for normal mice, at 250 Hz it's 4 ms, and if the mouse can be overclocked to 1000 Hz, it's 1 ms. Most mice will not support 1000 Hz, so don't try to go that high.

Of the mice we overclocked, the ones that seemed to offer the best performance improvements were the MX300 and MX500; upon bumping them up to 1000 Hz, they performed almost as well

as the legendary MX518, and all their skipping problems are taken care of. The same tweak should work with pretty much every USB mouse.

STEP 1. The first thing we did was checking the existing mouse rate using software called Mouse Rate Checker—www.tscherwitschke.de. You can also use a tiny application called Direct Input Mouse Rate. All we did was start Mouse Rate checker and move the mouse around randomly within the window. The polling rate is shown.

STEP 2. We decided to increase the polling rate in sane increments. We used a software called USB Mouserate Switcher—<http://tinyurl.com/hyonv>. After running it, we were prompted for whether we wanted to switch the polling rate to 250 Hz. After selecting Yes, we rebooted for the settings to be applied.

STEP 3. After the reboot, we checked the mouse, found it functional, and then restarted Mouse Rate Checker. It told us that the current rate was 250 Hz. Since the mouse was working perfectly, we decided to try for 500 Hz and increased the polling rate just as we had done in the previous step. We decided not to try 1000 Hz, and suggest that you do not either, because cheaper hardware just will not support it.

STEP 4. A well-known problem in XP is the acceleration bug, wherein mouse acceleration cannot be disabled. Those used to Windows 98's sensitivity would have noticed it while migrating to Windows XP. The only way is to fix it is to use a Registry key that disables it. We downloaded the fix from www.fpsbanana.com/tools/717; it's a WinRAR file, and we added the Registry key it contained.

Apart from what we did above, we also want to share other things we do to improve our input device performance, especially when gaming.

Mouse On A Diet?

Every gamer has his own choice of mouse weight. There's not much weight difference between what's considered

too light and what's too heavy, and even then there's no perfect mouse weight for everyone. Some Logitech mice, including the MX500, come with weights. These add to the resistance and result in slower reaction times in a game, but a steadier hand for, say, Photoshop work. We have found a lot of mice brands add dummy weight inside the mouse body, which can be reduced (or increased) depending on your preferences. Open your mouse up to see if it does have such weights.

Reshoe That Mouse

Mice need their "shoes" replaced when they get dirty and worn out. For cheaper mice, these shoes are made of Teflon or plastic, and wear out faster. Our secret to making these shoes last longer is to use cello tape. We just tape over the mouse feet, and this causes the mouse to move more smoothly, and also when the tape gets dirty, we just remove it, throw it away, and add more tape.

Nail It Down

We've noticed that a lot of us get restless when we're losing in a game, and this causes us to move the mouse around a lot more aggressively. It happens to any person who plays FPS games all the time, actually. Unfortunately, when this happens, we find ourselves hunting for our mouse pads under the table—because they're gone flying off when we make sudden jerky movements of the mouse. To solve this problem, a lot of us at Digit use big, heavy mouse pads; some don't use a mouse pad at all; others find the middle path—using regular mouse pads, but gluing them to the surface of the table. This only works if you have a fixed seating position, of course.

Remember, at the end of the day, any number of tips, tricks, and tweaks will not magically improve your game. Even a good player with a ball mouse can tackle mediocre players armed with expensive mice. The key is to practice a lot, but hopefully, this little DIY will give you a slight edge and improve your accuracy a little. ☒

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Answer
'n' Win

Answer 5 simple questions
and stake claim to a swanky
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